

## Lesson

## 3

## Actions

*Suit the action to the word, the word to the action.*

—WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE, *HAMLET*, 3.2

*I am unlikely to trust a sentence that comes easily.*

—WILLIAM GASS

## UNDERSTANDING JUDGMENTS

We have words enough to praise writing we like—*clear, direct, concise*—and more than enough to abuse writing we don't: *unclear, indirect, abstract, dense, complex*. We can use those words to distinguish these two sentences:

1a. The cause of our schools' failure at teaching basic skills is not understanding the influence of cultural background on learning.

1b. Our schools have failed to teach basic skills because they do not understand how cultural background influences the way a child learns.

Most of us would call (1a) too complex, (1b) clearer and more direct. But those words don't refer to anything *in* those sentences; they describe how those sentences make us *feel*. When we say that (1a) is unclear, we mean that *we* have a hard time understanding it; we say it's dense when *we* struggle to read it.

The problem is to understand what is in those two sentences that makes readers feel as they do. Only then can you rise above

your too-good understanding of your own writing to know when your readers will think it needs revising. To do that, you have to know what counts as a well-told story. (To profit from this lesson and the next three, you must be able to identify verbs, SIMPLE SUBJECTS, and WHOLE SUBJECTS. See the Glossary.)

## TELLING STORIES: CHARACTERS AND ACTIONS

This story has a problem:

2a. Once upon a time, as a walk through the woods was taking place on the part of Little Red Riding Hood, the Wolf's jump out from behind a tree occurred, causing her fright.

We prefer something closer to this:

✓ 2b. Once upon a time, Little Red Riding Hood was walking through the woods, when the Wolf jumped out from behind a tree and frightened her.

Most readers think (2b) tells the story more clearly than (2a) because it follows two principles:

- The main characters are subjects of verbs.
- Those verbs express specific actions.

## Principle of Clarity 1: Make Main Characters Subjects

Look at the subjects in (2a). The simple subjects (underlined> are *not* the main characters (italicized):

2a. Once upon a time, as a walk through the woods was taking place on the part of *Little Red Riding Hood*, the *Wolf's* jump out from behind a tree occurred, causing *her* fright.

Those subjects name not characters but actions expressed in abstract nouns, *walk* and *jump*:

## SUBJECT

a walk through the woods

the *Wolf's* jump out from behind a tree

## VERB

was taking place

occurred

The whole subject of *occurred* does have a character in it: the possessive noun *Wolf's jump*. But the Wolf is not *the* subject. It is only attached to the simple subject *jump*.

Contrast those abstract subjects with these, where the characters (italicized) are also the simple subjects (underlined):

- ✓ 2b. Once upon a time, Little Red Riding Hood was walking through the woods, when the Wolf jumped out from behind a tree and frightened her.

The subjects and the main characters are now the same words:

| SUBJECT/CHARACTER             | VERB        |
|-------------------------------|-------------|
| <u>Little Red Riding Hood</u> | was walking |
| <u>Wolf</u>                   | jumped      |

## Principle of Clarity 2: Make Important Actions Verbs

Now look at how the actions and verbs differ in (2a): the characters' actions are expressed not in verbs but in abstract nouns (actions are boldfaced; verbs are capitalized):

- 2a. Once upon a time, as a **walk** through the woods WAS TAKING place on the part of Little Red Riding Hood, the Wolf's **jump** out from behind a tree OCCURRED, causing her **fright**.

Note how vague the verbs are: *was taking, occurred*. The story isn't about *taking* and *occurring* but about *walking* and *jumping* and *frightening*. In (2b), the clearer sentence, the verbs name these important story actions:

- ✓ 2b. Once upon a time, Little Red Riding Hood WAS WALKING through the woods, when the Wolf JUMPED out from behind a tree and FRIGH-TENED her.

**Here's the point:** In (2a), the sentence that seems wordy and indirect, the two main characters, Little Red Riding Hood and the Wolf, are *not* subjects, and their actions—walking, jumping, and frightening—are *not* verbs. In (2b), the more direct sentence, those two main characters *are* subjects and their main actions *are* verbs. That's why we prefer (2b).

## FAIRY TALES AND "SERIOUS" WRITING

Writing in college or on the job may seem distant from fairy tales like "Little Red Riding Hood." But it's not, because in every kind

of writing, most sentences still tell stories. That is, they are still about characters doing things. Compare these two:

3a. The Federalists' argument in regard to the destabilization of government by popular democracy was based on their belief in the tendency of factions to further their self-interest at the expense of the common good.

- ✓ 3b. The Federalists argued that popular democracy destabilized government, because they believed that factions tended to further their self-interest at the expense of the common good.

We can analyze those sentences as we did the ones about Little Red Riding Hood.

Sentence (3a) feels dense for two reasons. First, its characters are not subjects. Its simple subject (underlined) is *argument*, but the characters (italicized) are *Federalists, popular democracy, government, and factions*:

3a. The *Federalists'* argument in regard to the destabilization of government by popular democracy was based on *their* belief in the tendency of *factions* to further *their* self-interest at the expense of the common good.

Second, the important actions (boldfaced) are not verbs (capitalized) but abstract nouns:

3a. The Federalists' **argument** in regard to the **destabilization** of government by popular democracy WAS BASED on their **belief** in the **tendency** of factions to FURTHER their self-interest at the expense of the common good.

Notice how long and complex is the whole subject of (3a) and how little meaning is expressed by its main verb *was based*:

| WHOLE SUBJECT                                                                                 | VERB      |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| The Federalists' argument in regard to the destabilization of government by popular democracy | was based |

Readers think (3b) is clearer for two reasons: most of the characters (italicized) are subjects (underlined), and the actions (boldfaced) are verbs (capitalized):

- ✓ 3b. The *Federalists* ARGUED that popular democracy DESTABILIZED government, because they BELIEVED that factions TENDED TO FURTHER their self-interest at the expense of the common good.

Note as well that when we make a character the simple subject, the whole subject (*The Federalists*) also becomes short and concrete.

In the rest of this lesson, we look at verbs and actions; in the next, at subjects and characters.

## VERBS AND ACTIONS

Our principle is this: a sentence seems clear when its important actions are in verbs. Look at how sentences (4a) and (4b) express their actions. In (4a), most of the actions (boldfaced) are not verbs (capitalized); they are nouns:

4a. Our **lack** of data **PREVENTED** **evaluation** of UN **actions** in **targeting** funds to areas most in **need** of **assistance**.

In (4b), on the other hand, the actions are almost all verbs:

✓ 4b. Because we **LACKED** data, we could not **EVALUATE** whether the UN **HAD TARGETED** funds to areas that most **NEEDED** **assistance**.

Readers will think your writing is dense if you use lots of abstract nouns, especially those derived from verbs and ADJECTIVES, nouns ending in *-tion*, *-ment*, *-ence*, and so on, and especially when you make those abstract nouns the subjects of verbs.

A noun derived from a verb or adjective has a technical name: nominalization. The word illustrates its meaning: when we nominalize *nominalize*, we create the nominalization *nominalization*. Here are a few examples:

| VERB → NOMINALIZATION | ADJECTIVE → NOMINALIZATION |
|-----------------------|----------------------------|
| discover → discovery  | careless → carelessness    |
| resist → resistance   | different → difference     |
| react → reaction      | proficient → proficiency   |

We can also nominalize a verb by adding *-ing* (making it a gerund):

She flies → her flying      We sang → our singing

Some nominalizations and verbs are identical:

hope → hope    result → result    repair → repair

We **REQUEST** that you **REVIEW** the data.

Our **request** is that you **DO** a **review** of the data.

(Some actions also hide out in adjectives: *It is applicable* → *it applies*. Some others: *indicative*, *dubious*, *argumentative*, *deserving*.)

No element of style more characterizes writing that feels dense, abstract, indirect, and difficult than lots of nominalizations, especially as the subjects of verbs.

**Here's the point:** In grade school, we learned that subjects *are* characters (or "doers") and that verbs *are* actions. That's often true:

|         |           |              |
|---------|-----------|--------------|
| subject | verb      | object       |
| We      | discussed | the problem. |
| doer    | action    |              |

But it is not true for this almost synonymous sentence:

|             |        |                              |
|-------------|--------|------------------------------|
| subject     | verb   | object                       |
| The problem | was    | the topic of our discussion. |
| doer        | action |                              |

We can move characters and actions around in a sentence, and subjects and verbs don't have to name any particular kind of thing at all. But when you match characters to subjects and actions to verbs in most of your sentences, readers are likely to think your prose is clear, direct, and readable.

### Exercise 3.1

If you aren't sure whether you can distinguish verbs, adjectives, and nominalizations, practice on the list below. Turn verbs and adjectives into nominalizations, and nominalizations into adjectives and verbs. Remember that some verbs and nominalizations have the same form:

Heavy rains **cause** flooding.

Heavy rains **ARE** a **cause** of flooding.

|            |             |             |            |            |
|------------|-------------|-------------|------------|------------|
| analysis   | believe     | attempt     | conclusion | evaluate   |
| suggest    | approach    | comparison  | define     | discuss    |
| expression | failure     | intelligent | thorough   | appearance |
| decrease   | improve     | increase    | accuracy   | careful    |
| emphasize  | explanation | description | clear      | examine    |

### Exercise 3.2

Identify the subject, character, verb, and action in these pairs of sentences. The unclear sentence is first; the improved sentence follows. What do you notice about how characters and subjects, and actions and verbs, are aligned in each?

- 1a. There is opposition among many voters to nuclear power plants based on a belief in their threat to human health.
- 1b. Many voters oppose nuclear power plants because they believe that such plants threaten human health.
- 2a. Growth in the market for electronic books is driven by the frequent preference among customers for their convenience and portability.
- 2b. The market for electronic books has grown because customers frequently prefer their convenience and portability.
- 3a. There is a belief among some researchers that consumers' choices in fast food restaurants are healthier because there are postings of nutrition information in menus.
- 3b. Some researchers believe that consumers are choosing healthier foods because fast food restaurants are posting nutrition information in their menus.
- 4a. The design of the new roller coaster was more of a struggle for the engineers than had been their expectation.
- 4b. The engineers struggled more than they expected when designing the new roller coaster.
- 5a. Because the student's preparation for the exam was thorough, none of the questions on it were a surprise.
- 5b. Because the student prepared thoroughly for the exam, she was not surprised by any of the questions on it.

### Exercise 3.3

Create three sentences using verbs and adjectives from Exercise 3.1. Then rewrite them using the corresponding nominalizations (keep the meaning the same). For example, using *suggest*, *discuss*, and *careful*, write:

I **SUGGEST** that we **DISCUSS** the issue **CAREFULLY**.

Then rewrite that sentence into its nominalized form:

My **suggestion** is that our **discussion** of the issue be done with **care**.

Only when you see how a clear sentence can be made unclear will you understand why it seemed clear in the first place.

### THE PROBLEM OF FAMILIARITY

Writers tend to write badly when they are unsure about what they want to say or how to say it. But they also tend to write badly because they are too familiar with their own writing to accurately judge how readers will respond to it.

You've probably had this experience: you think you've written something good, but your reader thinks otherwise. You wonder whether that person is just being difficult, but you bite your tongue and try to fix it, even though you think it should already be clear to anyone who can read Dr. Seuss. When that happens to me (regularly, I might add), I almost always realize—eventually—that my readers are right, that they see where my writing needs work better than I do.

Why are we so often right about the writing of others and so often wrong about our own? It is because we all read into our own writing what we want readers to get out of it. That explains why two readers can disagree about the clarity of the same piece of writing: the reader who is most familiar with its content will likely find it clearest. Both are right, because clarity is not a property of sentences but an impression of readers. It is in the eye of the beholder.

That is why we need to look at our own writing in a way that is almost mechanical, that sidesteps our too-good understanding of it. The quickest way is to follow the procedure below.

### HOW TO REVISE: CHARACTERS AND ACTIONS

You can use the two principles of clarity (make main characters subjects; make important actions verbs) to explain why your readers judge your prose as they do. But more important, you can also use them to identify and revise sentences that seem clear to you but will not to your readers. Revision is a three-step process: analyze, assess, rewrite.

#### 1. Analyze

- a. Ignoring short (four- or five-word) introductory phrases, underline the first seven or eight words in each sentence.

The automation of manufacturing, assembly, and shipping processes by corporations means the loss of jobs for many blue-collar workers.

- b. Then ask two questions:

- Did you underline any abstract nouns as simple subjects?

The automation of manufacturing, assembly, and shipping processes by corporations means the loss of jobs for many blue-collar workers.

- Did you underline seven or eight words before getting to a verb?

The automation of manufacturing, assembly, and shipping processes by corporations (10 words) **means** the loss of jobs for many blue-collar workers.

If you answer yes to either, you should probably revise.

## 2. Assess

- Decide who or what your main characters are (more about this in the next lesson).

The automation of manufacturing, assembly, and shipping processes by **corporations** means the loss of jobs for many **blue-collar workers**.

- Then look for the actions that those characters perform, especially actions hidden in nominalizations, those abstract nouns derived from verbs.

The **automation** of manufacturing, assembly, and shipping processes by corporations means the **loss** of jobs for many blue-collar workers.

## 3. Rewrite

- If the actions are nominalizations, make them verbs.

automation → automate    loss → lose

- Make the characters the subjects of those verbs.

corporations automate    blue-collar workers lose

- Rewrite the sentence with characters as subjects and actions as verbs, using subordinating conjunctions such as *because, if, when, although, why, how, whether*, or *that* to show relationships among ideas.

- ✓ Many blue-collar workers are losing their jobs **because** corporations are automating their manufacturing, assembly, and shipping processes.

## SOME COMMON PATTERNS

You can quickly spot and revise five common patterns of nominalizations.

- The nominalization is the subject of an empty verb such as *be, seems, has, etc.*:**

The **intention** of the committee **is** to audit the records.

- Change the nominalization to a verb:

intention → intend

- Find a character that would be the subject of that verb:

The intention of the *committee* is to audit the records.

- Make that character the subject of the new verb:

- ✓ The *committee* **INTENDS** to audit the records.

- The nominalization follows an empty verb:**

The *agency* **CONDUCTED** an **investigation** into the matter.

- Change the nominalization to a verb:

investigation → investigate

- Replace the empty verb with the new verb:

conducted → investigated

- ✓ The *agency* **INVESTIGATED** the matter.

- One nominalization is the subject of an empty verb and a second nominalization follows it:**

Our **loss** in sales **WAS** a result of their **expansion** of outlets.

- Revise the nominalizations into verbs:

loss → lose    expansion → expand

- Identify the characters that would be the subjects of those verbs:

Our **loss** in sales was a result of *their* **expansion** of outlets.

- Make those characters subjects of those verbs:

we lose    they expand

- Link the new clauses with a logical connection:

- To express simple cause: *because, since, when*
- To express conditional cause: *if, provided that, so long as*
- To contradict expected causes: *though, although, unless*

Our **loss** in sales → We **LOST** sales  
 was the result of → because  
 their **expansion** of outlets → they **EXPANDED** outlets

#### 4. A nominalization follows *there is* or *there are*:

There is no **need** for our further **study** of this problem.

##### a. Change the nominalization to a verb:

need → need study → study

##### b. Identify the character that should be the subject of the verb:

There is no **need** for *our* further **study** of this problem.

##### c. Make that character the subject of the verb:

no need → we need not our study → we study

✓ We **NEED** not **STUDY** this problem further.

#### 5. Two or three nominalizations in a row are joined by prepositions:

We did a **review** of the **evolution** of the brain.

##### a. Turn the first nominalization into a verb:

review → review

##### b. Either leave the second nominalization as it is, or turn it into a verb in a clause beginning with *how* or *why*:

evolution of the brain → how the brain evolved

✓ First, we **REVIEWED** the **evolution** of the *brain*.

✓ First, we **REVIEWED** how the brain **EVOLVED**.

**QUICK TIP** When you revise a complicated sentence, you will have more than one character-action clause. Decide how the clauses fit together, then try out these patterns: *X because Y; Since X, Y; If X, then Y; Although X, Y; X and/but/so Y.*

## SOME HAPPY CONSEQUENCES

When you consistently rely on verbs to express important actions, your readers benefit in many ways:

#### 1. Your sentences are more concrete. Compare:

There **WAS** an affirmative **decision** for **expansion**.

✓ *The director* **DECIDED** to **EXPAND** the program.

#### 2. Your sentences are more concise. When you use nominalizations, you have to add articles like *a* and *the* and prepositions such as *of*, *by*, and *in*. You don't need them when you use verbs and conjunctions:

A **revision** of the program **WILL RESULT in increases in** our **efficiency in the servicing** of clients.

✓ *If we* **REVISE** the program, we **CAN SERVE** clients more **EFFICIENTLY**.

#### 3. The logic of your sentences is clearer. When you nominalize verbs, you link actions with fuzzy prepositions and phrases such as *of*, *by*, and *on the part of*. But when you use verbs, you link clauses with precise subordinating conjunctions such as *because*, *although*, and *if*:

Our more effective presentation of our study resulted in our success, despite an earlier start by others.

✓ **Although** others started earlier, we succeeded **because** we presented our study more effectively.

#### 4. Your sentences tell more coherent stories. Nominalizations let you distort the sequence of actions. (The numbers refer to the real sequence of events.)

Decisions<sup>4</sup> in regard to administration<sup>5</sup> of medication despite inability<sup>2</sup> of irrational patients appearing<sup>1</sup> in a Trauma Center to provide legal consent<sup>3</sup> rest with the attending physician alone.

✓ When patients appear<sup>1</sup> in a Trauma Center and behave<sup>2</sup> so irrationally that they cannot legally consent<sup>3</sup> to treatment, only the attending physician can decide<sup>4</sup> whether to medicate<sup>5</sup> them.

### Exercise 3.4

One sentence in each of these pairs is clear, expressing characters as subjects and actions as verbs; the other is less clear, with actions in

nominalizations and characters often not in subjects. First, decide which is which. Then underline subjects, bracket verbs, box actions, and circle characters. What do you notice about where these words appear in the sentences?

- 1a. Some people argue that atmospheric carbon dioxide does not elevate global temperature.
- 1b. There has been speculation by educators about the role of the family in improving educational achievement.
- 2a. The store's price increases led to frustration among its customers.
- 2b. When we write concisely, readers understand easily.
- 3a. Researchers have identified the AIDS virus but have failed to develop a vaccine to immunize those at risk.
- 3b. Attempts by economists at defining full employment have been met with failure.
- 4a. Complaints by editorial writers about voter apathy rarely offer suggestions about dispelling it.
- 4b. Although critics claim that children who watch a lot of television tend to become less able readers, no one has demonstrated that to be true.
- 5a. The loss of market share to Japan by domestic automakers resulted in the disappearance of hundreds of thousands of jobs.
- 5b. When educators embrace new-media technology, our schools will teach complex subjects more effectively.
- 6a. We need to know which parts of our national forests are being logged most extensively so that we can save virgin stands at greatest risk.
- 6b. There is a need for an analysis of library use to provide a reliable base for the projection of needed resources.

### Exercise 3.5

Now revise the nominalized sentences in Exercise 3.4 into sentences in which the actions are verbs. Use its paired verbal version as a model. For example, if the verbal sentence begins with *when*, begin your revision with *when*:

- Sentence to revise: 2a. The store's price **increases** led to **frustration** among its customers.
- Model: 2b. When we **WRITE** concisely, readers **UNDERSTAND** more easily.
- Your revision: 2a. When the store **INCREASED** prices, . . .

### Exercise 3.6

Revise these next sentences so that the nominalizations are verbs and characters are their subjects. In (1) through (4), characters are italicized and nominalizations are boldfaced.

1. *Lincoln's hope* was for the **preservation** of the Union without war, but the *South's attack* on Fort Sumter made war an **inevitability**.
2. Attempts were made on the part of the *president's aides* to assert **his immunity** from a **congressional subpoena**.
3. There were **predictions** by *business executives* that the **economy** would experience a quick revival.
4. Your **analysis** of *my* report omits any data in **support** of *your criticism* of *my findings*.

In sentences 5 through 8, the characters are italicized; find the actions and revise.

5. Attempts at explaining increases in *voter participation* in this year's elections were made by *several candidates*.
6. The agreement by the *class* on the reading list was based on the assumption that there would be tests on only certain selections.
7. There was no independent *business-sector* study of the cause of the sudden increase in the trade surplus.
8. An understanding as to the need for controls over drinking on campus was recognized by *fraternities*.

### A QUALIFICATION: USEFUL NOMINALIZATIONS

I have so relentlessly urged you to turn nominalizations into verbs that you might think you should never use them. But in fact, you can't write well without them. The trick is to know which to keep and which to revise. Keep these:

1. A nominalization that is a short subject that refers to a previous sentence:
  - ✓ **These arguments** all depend on a single unproven claim.
  - ✓ **This decision** can lead to positive outcomes.

Those nominalizations link one sentence to another in a cohesive flow, an issue I'll discuss in more detail in Lesson 5.

2. **A short nominalization that replaces an awkward *The fact that*:**

The fact that she **ADMITTED** guilt impressed me.

- ✓ Her **admission** of guilt impressed me.

But then, why not this?

- ✓ She **IMPRESSED** me when she **ADMITTED** her guilt.

3. **A nominalization that names what would be the object of the verb:**

I accepted what she **REQUESTED** [that is, *She requested something*].

- ✓ I accepted her **request**.

Familiar nominalizations such as *request* feel more concrete than abstract ones. But when you can, you should still express actions as verbs:

Her **request** for **assistance** **CAME** after the deadline.

- ✓ She **REQUESTED assistance** after the deadline.

4. **A nominalization that refers to a concept so familiar to your readers that to them, it is a virtual character (more about this in the next lesson):**

- ✓ Few problems have so divided us as **abortion on demand**.
- ✓ The Equal Rights **Amendment** was an issue in past **elections**.
- ✓ **Taxation** without **representation** did not spark the American **Revolution**.

Those nominalizations name familiar concepts: *abortion on demand, amendment, election, taxation, representation, revolution*. You must develop an eye for distinguishing nominalizations expressing common ideas from those you can revise into verbs:

There is a **demand** for a **repeal** of the **inheritance** tax.

- ✓ We **DEMAND** that Congress **REPEAL** the **inheritance** tax.

## CLARITY, NOT SIMPLEMENTEDNESS

Your readers want you to write clearly, even simply—but not simplistically (see p. 21). Some argue that all sentences should be short, no more than fifteen words or so. But many mature ideas cannot

be expressed so compactly. In Lessons 10 and 11 we look at ways to write longer sentences that communicate complex ideas but are still readable.

## IN YOUR OWN WORDS

### Exercise 3.7

Go through a page of your own writing. Underline whole subjects and bracket verbs. Now, think about the story you are telling. Circle the main characters and box their actions, wherever they appear. Look especially for actions hidden in nominalizations. What do you notice? How clear will a reader likely find your writing? If necessary, revise to align characters with subjects and specific actions with verbs.

### Exercise 3.8

Writers tend to think their writing is clearer than their readers do. Select a page of your writing and share it with a reader. Both of you rate its clarity on a scale of 1–10, with 10 being perfectly clear and 1 being incomprehensible. Use the procedures for analyzing sentences on pages 35–36 to explain any differences in your ratings. Revise your writing if necessary.

## SUMMING UP

The two most general principles for clear sentences are these: make main characters the subjects of your verbs; make those characters' important actions your verbs.

We can represent these principles graphically. Readers must mentally integrate two levels of sentence structure. One, the grammatical level, is the relatively fixed sequence of subject and verb (the empty box is for everything that follows the verb):

|                 |         |      |  |               |
|-----------------|---------|------|--|---------------|
| Fixed Positions | Subject | Verb |  | Grammar Level |
|-----------------|---------|------|--|---------------|

The other, the story level, is based on characters and their actions and has no fixed order. Characters and actions can appear anywhere in a sentence, because writers can move them around.



But readers prefer them to align with subjects and verbs. We can represent this preference graphically:

|                  |           |        |       |               |
|------------------|-----------|--------|-------|---------------|
| Fixed Positions  | Subject   | Verb   | _____ | Grammar Level |
| Movable Elements | Character | Action | _____ | Story Level   |

Keep in mind that readers want to see characters not just *in* a subject, but *as* the subject. Not this:

The president's veto of the bill INFURIATED Congress.

The veto of the bill by the president INFURIATED Congress.

But this:

✓ When the president VETOED the bill, he INFURIATED Congress.

When you frustrate those expectations, you make readers work harder than necessary. So keep these principles in mind as you revise:

1. Express actions in verbs:

The **intention** of the committee is to improve morale.

✓ The committee **INTENDS** to improve morale.

2. Make the subjects of those verbs the characters associated with those actions:

A decision by the *dean* in regard to the funding of the program by the *department* is necessary for adequate *staff* preparation.

✓ The *staff* **CAN PREPARE** adequately, only after the *dean* **DECIDES** whether the *department* **WILL FUND** the program.

3. Don't revise nominalizations when:

a. they refer to a previous sentence:

✓ **These arguments** all depend on a single unproven claim.

b. they replace an awkward *the fact that*:

**The fact that she strenuously objected** impressed me.

✓ **Her strenuous objections** impressed me.

c. they name what would be the object of a verb:

I do not know **what she INTENDS**.

✓ I do not know **her intentions**.

d. they name a concept so familiar to your readers that it is a virtual character:

✓ Few issues have so divided us as **abortion on demand**.

✓ The Equal Rights **Amendment** was an issue in past **elections**.

## Lesson

## 4

# Characters

*Whatever is translatable in other and simpler words of the same language, without loss of sense or dignity, is bad.*

—SAMUEL TAYLOR COLERIDGE

*When character is lost, all is lost.*

—ANONYMOUS

## UNDERSTANDING CHARACTERS

Readers think sentences are clear and direct when they see key actions in their verbs. Compare (1a) with (1b):

1a. The EPA feared the president would recommend to Congress that it reduce its budget.

1b. The EPA had fears that the president would send a recommendation to Congress that it make a reduction in its budget.

Most readers think (1b) is a bit less clear than (1a), but not much. Now compare (1b) to (1c):

1c. The fear of the EPA was that a recommendation from the president to Congress would be for a reduction in its budget.

Most readers think that (1c) is much less clear than either (1a) or (1b).

The reason is this: In both (1a) and (1b), the important characters (*italicized*) are subjects (underlined) of verbs (**capitalized**):

1a. The EPA **FEARED** the president **WOULD RECOMMEND** to Congress that it **REDUCE** its budget.

1b. The EPA **HAD** fears that the president **WOULD SEND** a recommendation to Congress that it **MAKE** a reduction in its budget.

But in (1c) the two simple subjects (underlined) are not concrete characters but abstractions (**boldfaced**):

1c. The **fear** of the EPA **WAS** that a **recommendation** from the president to Congress **WOULD BE** for a **reduction** in its budget.

The different verbs in (1a) and (1b) matter somewhat, but the abstract subjects in (1c) matter more. Even worse, characters can be deleted entirely, like this:

1d. There **WAS** **fear** that there **WOULD BE** a **recommendation** for a budget **reduction**.

Who fears? Who recommends? The sentence's context may help readers guess correctly, but if the context is ambiguous, you risk them guessing wrongly.

**Here's the point:** Readers want actions in verbs, but they want characters as subjects even more. We create a problem for readers when for no good reason we fail to name characters in subjects or, worse, delete them entirely. It is important to express actions in verbs, but the *first* principle of a clear style is this: make the subjects of most of your verbs the main characters in your story.

## HOW TO REVISE: CHARACTERS AND ACTIONS (AGAIN)

To get characters into subjects, you have to know three things:

1. when your subjects are not characters
2. if they aren't, where you should look for characters
3. what you should do when you find them (or don't)

## The Basic Procedure

This sentence feels indirect and impersonal:

Governmental intervention in fast-changing technologies has led to the distortion of market evolution and interference in new product development.

We can analyze and revise it according to our procedure from Lesson 3:

1. **Underline the first seven or eight words:**

Governmental intervention in fast-changing technologies has led to the distortion of market evolution and interference in new product development.

In those first words, readers want to see characters not just in the whole subjects of verbs, as *government* is implied in *governmental*, but as their simple subjects. Here they aren't.

2. **Find the main characters.** They may be possessive nouns or pronouns attached to nominalizations, objects of prepositions (particularly *by* and *of*), or only implied. In that sentence, one main character is in the adjective *governmental*; the other, *market*, is in the object of a preposition: *of market evolution*.
3. **Skim the passage for actions involving those characters, particularly actions buried in nominalizations.** Ask *Who is doing what?*

|                                  |                                             |
|----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| <i>governmental intervention</i> | → ✓ <i>government intervenes</i>            |
| <i>distortion</i>                | → ✓ [ <i>government</i> ] <i>distorts</i>   |
| <i>market evolution</i>          | → ✓ <i>markets evolve</i>                   |
| <i>interference</i>              | → ✓ [ <i>government</i> ] <i>interferes</i> |
| <i>development</i>               | → ✓ [ <i>markets</i> ] <i>develop</i>       |

To revise, reassemble those new subjects and verbs into a sentence, using conjunctions such as *if*, *although*, *because*, *when*, *how*, and *why*:

- ✓ When a *government* **INTERVENES** in fast-changing technologies, it **DISTORTS** how *markets* **EVOLVE** and **INTERFERES** with their ability to **DEVELOP** new products.

Be aware that just as actions can be in adjectives (*reliable* → *rely*), so can characters:

Medieval *theological* debates often addressed issues considered trivial by modern *philosophical* thought.

When you find a character implied in an adjective, revise in the same way:

- ✓ *Medieval theologians* often debated issues that *modern philosophers* consider trivial.

**Here's the point:** The first step in analyzing a dense style is to look at subjects. If you do not see main characters as simple subjects, you have to look for them. They can be in objects of prepositions, in possessive pronouns, or in adjectives. Once you find them, look for actions they are involved in. When you are revising, make those characters the subjects of verbs naming those actions. When you are reading a dense passage, try to find characters and their actions, and retell the story to yourself.

## RECONSTRUCTING ABSENT CHARACTERS

Readers have the biggest problem with sentences devoid of *all* characters:

A decision was made in favor of doing a study of the disagreements.

That sentence could mean either of these, and more:

We decided that I should study why they disagreed.

I decided that you should study why he disagreed.

The writer may know who is doing what, and readers may be able to guess from context. But often they can't and will need help.

Sometimes we omit characters to make a general statement:

Research strategies that look for more than one variable are of more use in understanding factors in psychiatric disorder than strategies based on the assumption that the presence of psychopathology is dependent on a single gene or on strategies in which only one biological variable is studied.

But when we try to revise that into something clearer, we have to invent characters and then decide what to call them. Do we use *one*, *we* or *you*? Do we name a generic "doer"?

- ✓ If *one/we/you/researchers* are to understand what causes psychiatric disorder, *one/we/you/they* should use research strategies that look for more than one variable rather than assume that a single gene is responsible for a psychopathology or adopt a strategy in which *one/we/you/they* study only one biological variable.

To most of us, *one* feels stiff, but *we* may be ambiguous because it can refer just to the writer, or to the writer and others but not the reader, or to the reader and writer but not others, or to everyone.

And if you are not directly addressing your reader, *you* is usually inappropriate.

But if you avoid both nominalizations and vague pronouns, you can slide into passive verbs (I'll discuss them in a moment):

To understand what makes patients vulnerable to psychiatric disorders, strategies that look for more than one variable **SHOULD BE USED** rather than strategies in which a gene **IS ASSUMED** to cause psychopathology or only one biological variable **IS STUDIED**.

To reconstruct missing characters, you have to use your judgment. In general, choose the most specific characters you can find.

**QUICK TIP** When you are explaining a complicated issue to someone involved in it, imagine sitting across the table from that person, saying *you* as often as you can:

Taxable intangible property includes financial notes and municipal bonds. A one-time tax of 2% on its value applies to this property.

- ✓ **You** have to pay tax on **your** intangible property, including **your** financial notes and municipal bonds. On this property, **you** pay a one-time tax of 2%.

If *you* is not appropriate, change it to a character that is:

**Taxpayers** have to pay tax on their intangible property, including **their** financial notes and municipal bonds. **They** pay . . .

## ABSTRACTIONS AS CHARACTERS

So far, I've discussed characters as if they must be flesh-and-blood people. But inanimate things and even abstractions can serve as characters, so long as you make them the subjects of a series of sentences that tell a story. For instance, we might have solved the problem of the previous example by choosing *studies* as our character:

- ✓ To understand what causes psychiatric disorders, *studies* should look for more than one variable rather than adopt a strategy in which *they* test only one biological variable or assume that a single gene is responsible for a psychopathology.

Now the sentence is clear but also appropriately professional.

You can also tell stories whose main characters are abstractions, even nominalizations, so long as you make them

subjects of a series of sentences and clauses. Here's a story about *freedom of speech*, a familiar abstraction made up of two nominalizations (subjects are underlined; verbs are capitalized):

No human right is more basic than *freedom of speech*, *which* **ENSURES** individual expression and **GUARANTEES** the open flow of ideas in society. It **AROSE** as a pillar of modern political thought during the late eighteenth century, and in 1948, it **WAS RECOGNIZED** by the United Nations as a universal right. It protects not only unpopular political views but also other forms of controversial expression, including artistic expression. Nevertheless, *freedom of speech* is not absolute: it **IS BOUNDED** by other rights and principles, including. . .

Like *studies* in the last example, *freedom of speech* becomes a character because it (or an associated pronoun like *which* or *it*) appears as the subject of verbs that state specific actions: *ensures*, *guarantees*, *arose*, and so on. In this case, two passive verbs, *was recognized* and *is bounded*, keep the phrase in the subject position.

But when you use abstractions as characters, you can create a problem. A story about an abstraction as familiar as *freedom of speech* is clear enough, but if you surround an unfamiliar abstract character with a lot of other abstractions, readers may feel that your writing is unnecessarily dense.

For example, few of us are familiar with the terms *prospective intention* and *immediate intention*, so most of us are likely to struggle with a story about them, especially when they are surrounded by other abstractions (actions are boldfaced; human characters are italicized):

The **argument** is this. The cognitive component of **intention** exhibits a high degree of **complexity**. **Intention** is temporally divisible into two: prospective **intention** and immediate **intention**. The cognitive function of prospective **intention** is the **representation** of a *subject's* similar past **actions**, *his* current situation, and *his* course of future **actions**. That is, the cognitive component of prospective **intention** is a **plan**. The cognitive function of immediate **intention** is the **monitoring** and **guidance** of ongoing bodily **movement**.

—Myles Brand, *Intending and Acting: Toward a Naturalized Action Theory*

We can make that passage clearer if we tell its story from the point of view of flesh-and-blood characters (italicized; actions are boldfaced; verbs are capitalized):

- ✓ **I ARGUE** this about **intention**. **It HAS** a complex cognitive component of two temporal kinds: prospective and immediate. **We USE** prospective **intention** to **REPRESENT** how *we* **HAVE ACTED** in our past and present and how *we* **WILL ACT** in the future. That is, *we*

USE the cognitive component of prospective **intention** to **HELP** us **PLAN**. We **USE** immediate **intention** to **MONITOR** and **GUIDE** our bodies as we **MOVE** them.

But have I made this passage say something that the writer didn't mean? Some argue that any change in form changes meaning. In this case, the writer might offer an opinion, but only his readers could decide whether the two passages have different meanings, because at the end of the day, a passage means only what careful and competent readers think it does.

**Here's the point:** Most readers want the subjects of verbs to name flesh-and-blood characters. But often, you must write about abstractions. When you do, turn them into virtual characters by making them the subjects of verbs that tell a story. If readers are familiar with your abstractions, no problem. But when they are not, avoid using lots of other abstract nominalizations around them. When you revise an abstract passage, you may have a problem if the hidden characters are "people in general." Unfortunately, unlike many other languages, English offers no good way to name a generic "doer." Try a general term for whoever is doing the action, such as *researchers*, *social critics*, *one*, and so on. If that won't work, try *we*.

### Exercise 4.1

Analyze and revise these sentences so that each has a specific character as the subject of a specific verb. To revise, you may have to invent characters. Use *we*, *I*, or any other word that seems appropriate. For the first four sentences, I suggest possible characters in brackets.

1. Contradictions among the data require an explanation. [we]
2. Having their research taken seriously by professionals in the field was hard work for the students. [student researchers]
3. In recent years, the appearance of new interpretations about the meaning of the discovery of America has led to a reassessment of Columbus's place in Western history. [historians]

4. Resistance has been growing against building mental health facilities in residential areas because of a belief that the few examples of improper management are typical. [residents]
5. A decision about forcibly administering medication in an emergency room setting despite the inability of an irrational patient to provide legal consent is usually an on-scene medical decision.
6. The performance of the play was marked by enthusiasm, but there was a lack of intelligent staging.
7. Despite the critical panning of the show's latest season the love of the loyal fans was not affected.
8. The rejection of the proposal was a disappointment but not a surprise because our expectation was that a political decision had been made.

## CHARACTERS AND PASSIVE VERBS

More than any other advice, you probably remember *Write in the active voice, not the passive*. That's not bad advice, but it has exceptions.

When you write in the active voice, you typically put

- the AGENT or source of an action in the subject
- the GOAL or receiver of an action in a DIRECT OBJECT:

|                | subject         | verb   | object    |
|----------------|-----------------|--------|-----------|
| <b>Active:</b> | I               | lost   | the money |
|                | character/agent | action | goal      |

A verb is in the passive voice when its PAST PARTICIPLE is preceded by a form of *be* (as it is in this next example). The passive differs from the active in two ways:

- The subject names the goal of the action.
- The agent or source of the action is after the verb in a *by*-phrase or dropped entirely:

|                 | subject   | be + verb | prepositional phrase |
|-----------------|-----------|-----------|----------------------|
| <b>Passive:</b> | The money | was lost  | [by me].             |
|                 | goal      | action    | character/agent      |

The terms *active* and *passive* are ambiguous, however, because they can refer both to those two *grammatical constructions* and to how a sentence *makes you feel*. We call a sentence *passive* if it feels flat, even if its verb is not in the passive voice. Compare these two sentences:

We can manage the problem if we control costs.

Problem management requires cost control.

Grammatically, both sentences are in the active voice, but the second *feels* passive for three reasons:

- Neither of its actions—*management* and *control*—are verbs; both are nominalizations.
- The subject is *problem management*, an abstraction.
- The sentence lacks flesh-and-blood characters.

To understand why we respond to those two sentences as we do, we have to keep these meanings distinct. In what follows, I discuss grammatical passives.

### Choosing Between Active and Passive

Some critics of style tell us to avoid the passive everywhere because it adds words and often deletes the character or agent, the “doer” of the action. But the passive is sometimes the better choice. To choose between active and passive, you have to answer three questions:

#### 1. Must your readers know who is responsible for the action?

Often, we don’t say who does an action because we don’t know or readers won’t care. We naturally choose the passive in these sentences:

- ✓ The president **WAS RUMORED** to have considered resigning.
- ✓ Those who **ARE FOUND** guilty can **BE FINED**.
- ✓ Valuable records should always **BE KEPT** in a safe.

If we do not know who spreads rumors, we cannot say. And no one doubts who finds people guilty or fines them or who should keep records safe, so we don’t have to say. So those passives are the right choice.

Sometimes, of course, writers use the passive when they don’t want readers to know who is responsible for an action, especially when the doer is the writer:

Because the test **WAS** not **COMPLETED**, the flaw **WAS UNCORRECTED**.

I will discuss the issue of intended impersonality in Lesson 12.

#### 2. Would the active or passive verb help your readers move more smoothly from one sentence to the next?

We depend on the beginning of a sentence to give us a context of what we know before we read what’s new. A sentence confuses us when it opens with information that is new and unexpected. In this next passage, the subject of the second sentence gives us new and complex information (boldfaced) before we read more familiar information that we recall from the previous sentence (italicized):

We must decide whether to improve education in the sciences alone or to raise the level of education across the whole curriculum. **The weight given to industrial competitiveness as opposed to the value we attach to the liberal arts** *WILL DETERMINE* *our decision*.

new information  
active verb familiar information

In the second sentence, the verb *determine* is in the active voice. But we could read the sentence more easily if it were passive, because the passive would put the short, familiar information (*our decision*) first and the newer, more complex information last, the order we prefer:

- ✓ We must decide whether to improve education in the sciences alone or raise the level of education across the whole curriculum. *Our decision* **WILL BE DETERMINED** **by the weight we give to industrial competitiveness as opposed to the value we attach to the liberal arts**.
- familiar information passive verb new information

I discuss where to put old and new information more extensively in Lesson 5.

#### 3. Would the active or passive give readers a more consistent and appropriate point of view?

The writer of this next passage reports the end of World War II in Europe from the point of view of the Allies. To do so, she uses active verbs to make the Allies a consistent sequence of subjects:

- ✓ By early 1945, *the Allies* **HAD** essentially **DEFEATED** *Germany*; all that remained was a bloody climax. *American, French, British, and Russian forces* **HAD BREACHED** *its borders* and **WERE BOMBING** *it* around the clock. But *they* **HAD** not yet **SO DEVASTATED** *Germany* as to destroy its ability to resist.
- active active active active

Had she wanted to explain history from the German point of view, she would have used passive verbs to make Germany the subject/character:

- ✓ By early 1945, *Germany* **HAD** essentially **BEEN DEFEATED**; *all* that remained was a bloody climax. *Its borders* **HAD BEEN BREACHED**, and *it* **WAS BEING BOMBED** around the clock. *It* **HAD** not **BEEN SO DEVASTATED**, however, that *it* could not **RESIST**.
- passive passive passive passive active

**Here's the point:** Many writers use the passive too often, but you will struggle to write clearly if you avoid it entirely. Use it in these contexts:

- You don't know who did an action, readers don't care, or you don't want them to know.
- You want to shift a long, unfamiliar, or complex bundle of information to the end of a sentence, especially when doing so lets you begin with a bundle that is shorter, more familiar, or simpler.
- You want to focus your readers' attention on a particular character.

### Exercise 4.2

In the following, change all active verbs into passives, and all passives into actives. Which sentences improve? Which do not? (In the first two, active verbs that could be passive are italicized; verbs already passive are boldfaced.)

1. Independence is **gained** by young people when skills are **learned** that the marketplace *values*.
2. Different planes of the painting are **noticed**, because their colors are **set** against a background of shades of gray that are **laid** on in layers that cannot be **seen** unless the surface is **examined** closely.
3. In this article, it is argued that the Vietnam War was fought to extend influence in Southeast Asia and was not ended until it was made clear that the United States could not defeat North Vietnam unless atomic weapons were used.
4. Science education will not be improved in this nation to a level sufficient to ensure that American industry will be supplied with skilled workers and researchers until more money is provided to primary and secondary schools.

### The "Objective" Passive vs. *I/We*

Some scholarly writers use the passive voice to avoid first-person subjects (*I* and *we*) and create an objective point of view:

Based on the writers' verbal intelligence, prior knowledge, and essay scores, their essays **WERE ANALYZED** for structure and

evaluated for richness of concepts. The subjects **WERE** then **DIVIDED** into a high- or low-ability group. Half of each group **WAS** randomly **ASSIGNED** to a treatment group or to a placebo group.

The writer could have written this:

Based on the writers' verbal intelligence, prior knowledge, and essay scores, *I* **ANALYZED** their essays for structure and **EVALUATED** them for richness of concepts. *I* then **SEPARATED** the subjects into high- and low-ability groups. *I* randomly **ASSIGNED** half of each group to a treatment group or to a placebo group.

Is that less objective? Opinions differ, but I don't think so. Nevertheless, the practice of using the passive voice to eliminate first-person subjects is common, especially in the natural and social sciences.

I would note, however, that this impersonal, "scientific" style is a modern development. In his "New Theory of Light and Colors" (1672), Sir Isaac Newton wrote this charming first-person account of an experiment:

I procured a triangular glass prism, to try therewith the *celebrated phenomena* of colours. And in order thereto, having darkened my chamber, and made a small hole in my window-shuts, to let in a convenient quantity of the sun's light, I placed my prism at its entrance, that it might be thereby refracted to the opposite wall. It was at first a very pleasing divertisement to view the vivid and intense colours produced thereby...

Were Newton writing for a scientific journal today, he might have started, "A triangular glass prism was procured. . . ."

But even today, scholars, including scientists, don't use this dense, impersonal style all the time. In fact, they use the active voice and *I* and *we* regularly. These next passages come from articles in respected journals:

- ✓ This paper is concerned with two problems. Briefly: how can we best handle in a transformational grammar, (i) Restrictions on . . . , To illustrate, we may cite . . . , we shall show . . .

—P.H. Matthews, "Problems of Selection in Transformational Grammar," *Journal of Linguistics*

- ✓ The survey assessed approximately fifty political-cultural variables, too many to examine in a single paper. As a first step, we have selected for discussion certain items which involve the cultural requisites for democracy. . . .

—Andrew J. Nathan and Tianjian Shi, "Cultural Requisites for Democracy in China: Findings from a Survey," *Daedalus*



Here are the first few words of several consecutive sentences from an article in *Science*, a journal of great prestige:

- ✓ **We** examine . . . , **We** compare . . . , **We** have used . . . , Each has been weighted . . . , **We** merely take . . . , They are subject . . . , **We** use . . . , Efron and Morris describe . . . , **We** observed . . . , **We** might find . . .

—John P. Gilbert, Bucknam McPeck, and Frederick Mosteller,  
"Statistics and Ethics in Surgery and Anesthesia," *Science*

It is not true that academic writers always avoid the first person. But they do tend to use it in certain places and in certain ways. Most commonly, the first person appears in what is called **METADISCOURSE**.

## Metadiscourse

Look again at the passages above. The first, with its passive verbs, describes research procedures that anyone could do. The other passages, those that use active verbs and the first person, describe the writers' own writing and thinking. These passages are examples of *metadiscourse*, or language that refers not to a writer's subject matter but to the writer, the reader, or the writing itself (the Greek prefix "meta-" means "after" or, in this context, "about").

Metadiscourse can appear anywhere, but it is most common in introductions and conclusions, where writers explain what they are going to do or what they have done. While you should not use metadiscourse excessively (see Lesson 9), most writing contains some, and it can help your readers follow and understand you better. Here are some ways you can use metadiscourse:

- To explain your thinking or writing: *In this paper, we will argue/claim/show. . . ; I conclude from these data that. . .*
- To trace logic or form of your argument: *First . . . ; In addition . . . ; Most important . . . ; Consequently. . .*
- To address your readers: *As you recall . . . ; Consider. . .*
- To describe the organization of your document: *This paper is divided into three parts . . . ; Our argument proceeds as follows. . .*
- To refer to other parts of your document: *In the passage above . . . ; As demonstrated by Figure 1. . .*
- To express a stance or point of view: *Not unexpectedly . . . ; We concur that . . . ; It seems unlikely that. . .*
- To hedge or intensify your argument: *usually, perhaps, seems, in some respects . . . ; very, clearly, certainly . . .* (I discuss hedges and intensifiers more in Lesson 9.)

**Here's the point:** Some writers and editors avoid the first person by using the passive everywhere, but deleting an *I* or *we* doesn't make a researcher's thinking more objective. We know that behind those impersonal sentences are still flesh-and-blood people doing, thinking, and writing. In fact, the first-person *I* and *we* are common in scholarly prose when used with verbs that name actions unique to the writer.

## Exercise 4.3

The verbs in 1 through 4 below are passive, but two could be active because they are metadiscourse verbs that would take first-person subjects. Revise the passive verbs that should be changed into active verbs. Then go through each sentence again and revise nominalizations into verbs as needed.

1. It is believed that a lack of understanding about the risks of alcohol is a cause of student bingeing.
2. The model has been subjected to extensive statistical analysis.
3. Success in exporting more crude oil for hard currency is suggested here as the cause of the improvement of the Russian economy.
4. The creation of a database is being considered, but no estimate has been made in regard to the potential of its usefulness.

The verbs in 5 through 8 are active, but some of them should be passive because they are not metadiscourse verbs. Revise the active verbs that should be changed into passive verbs, and revise in other ways as needed.

5. In Section IV, I argue that the indigenous peoples engaged in overcultivation of the land, leading to its exhaustion as a food-producing area.
6. Our intention in this book is to help readers achieve an understanding not only of the differences in grammar between Arabic and English but also the differences in worldview as reflected by Arabic vocabulary.
7. To make an evaluation of changes in the flow rate, I made a comparison of the current rate with the original rate on the basis of figures I had compiled with figures that Jordan had collected.
8. We performed the tissue rejection study on the basis of methods developed with our discovery of increases in dermal sloughing as a result of cellular regeneration.



## Noun + Noun + Noun

One more stylistic choice does not directly involve characters and actions, but I discuss it here because it can distort the match that readers expect between the form of an idea and the grammar of its expression. It is the long COMPOUND NOUN phrase:

*Early childhood thought disorder misdiagnosis* often results from unfamiliarity with recent *research literature* describing such conditions. This paper is a review of seven recent studies in which are findings of particular relevance to *pre-adolescent hyperactivity diagnosis* and to *treatment modalities* involving *medication maintenance level evaluation procedures*.

It is fine to modify one noun with another, as common phrases such as *stone wall*, *student center*, *space shuttle*, and many others show.

But strings of nouns feel lumpy, so avoid them, especially ones you invent. Revise compound nouns of your own invention, especially when they include nominalizations. Just reverse the order of words and find prepositions to connect them:

|             |            |         |          |              |
|-------------|------------|---------|----------|--------------|
| 1           | 2          | 3       | 4        | 5            |
| early       | childhood  | thought | disorder | misdiagnosis |
| misdiagnose | disordered | thought | in early | childhood    |
| 5           | 4          | 3       | 1        | 2            |

Reassembled, it looks like this:

Physicians misdiagnose<sup>5</sup> disordered<sup>4</sup> thought<sup>3</sup> in young<sup>1</sup> children<sup>2</sup> because they are unfamiliar with recent literature on the subject.

If, however, a long compound noun includes a technical term in your field, keep that part of the compound and unpack the rest:

Physicians misdiagnose<sup>5</sup> **thought disorders**<sup>3,4</sup> in young<sup>1</sup> children<sup>2</sup> because they are unfamiliar with recent literature on the subject.

### Exercise 4.4

Identify and revise the strings of nouns in these sentences:

1. Diabetic patient blood pressure reduction may be brought about by renal depressor application.
2. The goal of this article is to describe text comprehension processes and recall protocol production.

3. On the basis of these principles, we may now attempt to formulate narrative information extraction rules.
4. This paper is an investigation into information processing behavior involved in computer human cognition simulation.
5. Enforcement of guidelines for new automobile tire durability must be a Federal Trade Commission responsibility.
6. The Social Security program is a monthly income floor guarantee based on a lifelong contribution schedule.

## CLARITY AND THE PROFESSIONAL VOICE

Every group expects its members to show that they accept its values by adopting its distinctive voice. The apprentice banker must learn not only to think and look like a banker but also to speak and write like one. Too often, though, aspiring professionals try to join the club by writing in its most complex technical language. When they do, they adopt an exclusionary style that erodes the trust a civil society depends on, especially in a world where information and expertise are the means to power and control.

It is true that some research can never be made clear to intelligent lay readers—but less often than many researchers think. Here is an excerpt from Talcott Parsons, a social scientist who was as revered for his influence on his field as he was ridiculed for the opacity of his prose.

Apart from theoretical conceptualization there would appear to be no method of selecting among the indefinite number of varying kinds of factual observation which can be made about a concrete phenomenon or field so that the various descriptive statements about it articulate into a coherent whole, which constitutes an “adequate,” a “determinate” description. Adequacy in description is secured insofar as determinate and verifiable answers can be given to all the scientifically important questions involved. What questions are important is largely determined by the logical structure of the generalized conceptual scheme which, implicitly or explicitly, is employed.

We can make that clearer to moderately well-educated readers:

Without a theory, scientists have no way to select from everything they could say about a subject only that which they can fit into a coherent whole that would be an “adequate” or “determinate” description. Scientists describe something “adequately” only when they can verify answers to all the questions they think are important. They decide what questions are important based on their implicit or explicit theories.

And we could make it even more concise:

Whatever you describe, you need a theory to fit its parts into a whole. You need a theory not only to verify answers but even to decide what questions to ask.

My versions lose the nuances of Parsons's passage, and the last one loses some of its content. But his excruciatingly dense style numbs all but his most masochistically dedicated readers. Most readers would accept the tradeoff.

Einstein said that everything should be made as simple as possible, but no simpler. Accordingly, your writing should be as complex as necessary, *but no more*.

## IN YOUR OWN WORDS

### Exercise 4.5

Go through a page of your own writing. Circle all of the nominalizations and label all of the verbs as active or passive. For each nominalization and for each passive verb, state the specific reason you used it. If you cannot give a reason, revise it.

### Exercise 4.6

Select a passage from a major work in your field. With a partner, analyze its professional voice. What sorts of characters does it use? What is the balance between active and passive verbs? How are nominalizations used? How, and how extensively, does it use metadiscourse? Try to distinguish traits specific to this work from those that characterize the *field's* professional voice. Now, revise a passage of your own writing so that it imitates that voice. What did you have to change?

## SUMMING UP

1. Readers judge prose to be clear when subjects of sentences name characters and verbs name actions.

|                  |           |        |       |               |
|------------------|-----------|--------|-------|---------------|
| Fixed Positions  | Subject   | Verb   | _____ | Grammar Level |
| Movable Elements | Character | Action | _____ | Story Level   |

2. If you tell a story in which you make abstract nominalizations its main characters and subjects, use as few other nominalizations as you can:

*A nominalization* is a **replacement** of a verb by a noun, often resulting in **displacement** of characters from subjects by nouns.

- ✓ When *a nominalization* **REPLACES** a verb with a noun, *it* often **DISPLACES** characters from subjects.

3. Use a passive if the agent of an action is self-evident:

*The voters* **REELECTED** the president with 54% of the vote.

- ✓ *The president* **WAS REELECTED** with 54% of the vote.

4. Use a passive if it lets you replace a long subject with a short one:

Research demonstrating the soundness of our reasoning and the need for action **SUPPORTED** *this decision*.

- ✓ *This decision* **WAS SUPPORTED BY** research demonstrating the soundness of our reasoning and the need for action.

5. Use a passive if it gives your readers a coherent sequence of subjects:

- ✓ By early 1945, *the Axis nations* had **BEEN** essentially **DEFEATED**; all that remained was a bloody climax. *The German borders* had **BEEN BREACHED**, and both *Germany and Japan* were being bombed around the clock. *Neither country*, though, had **BEEN** so **DEVASTATED** that *it* could not **RESIST**.

6. Use an active verb if it is a metadiscourse verb:

The terms of the analysis must **BE DEFINED**.

- ✓ We must **DEFINE** the terms of the analysis.

7. When possible, rewrite long compound noun phrases:

We discussed the **board**<sup>1</sup> **candidate**<sup>2</sup> **review**<sup>3</sup> **meeting**<sup>4</sup> **schedule**<sup>5</sup>.

- ✓ We discussed the **schedule**<sup>5</sup> of **meetings**<sup>4</sup> to **review**<sup>3</sup> **candidates**<sup>2</sup> for the **board**<sup>1</sup>.